Types of Plant Hormones

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There are five major classes of plant hormones. They are:

1. Auxins
2. Cytokinins
3. Gibberellins
4. Abscisic Acid (ABA)
5. Ethylene

Among all these plant hormones auxins, cytokinins and gibberellins promote plant growth while abscisic acid and ethylene inhibit plant growth.

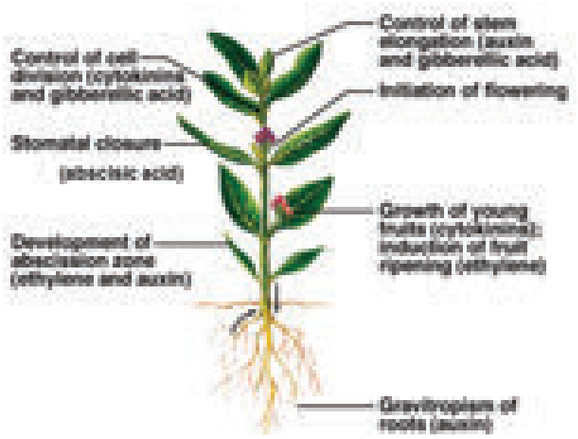


Figure 16.1 Hormonal interaction in plant growth and development

16.1.1 Auxins

Auxins (Gk. auxein = to grow) were the first plant hormones discovered. The term auxin was introduced by Kogl and Haagen-Smith (1931). Auxins are **produced at the tip of stems and roots** from where they migrate to the zone of elongation. Charles Darwin (1880), observed unilateral growth and curvature of canary grass *(Phalaris canariensis)* coleoptiles. He came to the conclusion that some 'influence' was transmitted from the tip of the coleoptile to the basal region. This 'influence' was later identified as Auxin by Went.

16.1.1.1 Went's Experiment

Frits Warmolt Went (1903– 1990), a Dutch biologist demonstrated the existence and effect of auxin in plants. He did a series of experiments in Avena coleoptiles.

In his first experiment he removed the tips of Avena coleoptiles. The cut tips did not grow indicating that the tips produced something essential for growth.In his second experiment he placed the agar blocks on the decapitated coleoptile tips. The coleoptile tips did not show any response. In his next experiment he placed the detached coleoptile tips on agar blocks. After an hour, he discarded the tips and placed this agar block on the decapitated coleoptile. It grew straight up indicating that some chemical had diffused from the cut coleoptile tips into the agar block which stimulated the growth.

From his experiments Went concluded that a chemical diffusing from the tip of coleoptiles was responsible for growth, and he named it as "**Auxin**" meaning '**to grow**".

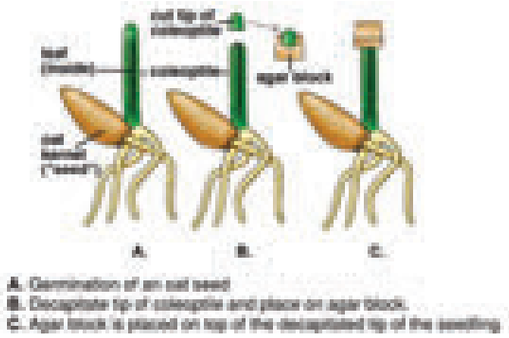


Figure 16.2 Went's Experiment

Types of Auxins: Auxins are classified into two types, namely natural auxins and synthetic auxins.

1. **Natural Auxins:** Auxins produced by the plants are called natural auxins. Example: IAA (Indole – 3 - Acetic Acid)
2. **Synthetic Auxins:** Artificially synthesized auxins that have properties like auxins are called as synthetic auxins. Example: 2, 4 D (2,4 Dichlorophenoxy Acetic Acid).

Physiological effects of auxins: Auxins bring about a variety of physiological effects in different parts of the plant body.

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